Steven Foley

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Research interests: psycholinguistics · formal and experimental syntax · Georgian and languages of the Caucasus · case and agreement · incremental sentence comprehension · relative clauses · prominence scales · innovation and language change · individual variation · singular *they* · cataphora · pronoun movement and PCCs · fieldwork · experiments outside the lab

Employment

8/2024 – 7/2026	**University of Georgia**, Athens, GA Visiting assistant professor
1/2023 – 7/2024	**University of Southern California**, Los Angeles, CA Postdoctoral teaching fellow
9/2020 – 8/2022	**Princeton University**, Princeton, NJ Postdoctoral research associate and lecturer

Education

9/2014 – 6/2020	**University of California Santa Cruz**, Santa Cruz, CA Ph.D. in Linguistics Dissertation advisors: Maziar Toosarvandani and Matt Wagers
9/2010 – 5/2013	**New York University**, New York City, NY B.A. in Linguistics, *summa cum laude* Senior thesis advisor: Stephanie Harves

Research output

Peer-reviewed journal articles

Foley, Steven and Nino Amiridze. 2026. Where does *that* fit in? Morphological variation and reanalysis in Georgian placeholder verbs. *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory*, 43:37. DOI: https://doi.org/10.1007/s11049-026-09721-8

Foley, Steven and Byron Ahn. 2024. Processing cataphoric *they* amidst pronominal variation. *Journal of Cultural Cognitive Science*. 8: 289–308. DOI: https://doi.org/10.1007/s41809-024-00153-7

Foley, Steven and Maziar Toosarvandani. 2022. Extending the Person–Case Constraint to gender: Agreement, locality, and the syntax of pronouns. *Linguistic Inquiry*. 53(1): 1–40. DOI: https://doi.org/10.1162/ling_a_00395

Manuscripts

Foley, Steven and Matt Wagers. 2026 [Submitted for peer review]. Disambiguation of case alignment pattern, not gap position, impedes the processing of filler/gap dependencies in a split ergative language. Manuscript, University of California Santa Cruz.

Foley, Steven. 2026 [Under revision]. Processing the disambiguation of grammatical roles: Lexicality Maze evidence from Georgian. Manuscript, University of Georgia.

Sasaki, Kelsey, Steven Foley, Jed Pizarro-Guevara, Fe Silva-Robles, Maziar Toosarvandani, and Matt Wagers. 2026 [In preparation]. Evidence for a universal parsing principle in Santiago Laxopa Zapotec. Manuscript, University of California Santa Cruz.

Invited contributions

Erschler, David, Steven Foley, and Léa Nash. Under contract. The South Caucasian Languages. In Balkız Öztürk, Maria Polinsky, and Stavros Skopeteas (eds.), *The Cambridge Handbook of Caucasian Languages*. Cambridge University Press.

Foley, Steven. 2021. Agreement in the languages of the Caucasus. In Maria Polinsky (ed.), *The Oxford Handbook of Languages of the Caucasus*. Oxford University Press. 845–872.

Adler, Jeff, Steven Foley, Jed Pizarro-Guevara, Kelsey Sasaki, and Maziar Toosarvandani. 2018. The derivation of verb initiality in Santiago Laxopa Zapotec. In Jason Merchant, Line Mikkelsen, Deniz Rudin, and Kelsey Sasaki (eds.), *A Reasonable Way to Proceed: Essays in honor of Jim McCloskey*. 31–49.

Theses

Foley, Steven. 2020. Case, agreement, and sentence processing in Georgian. Ph.D. dissertation, University of California Santa Cruz.

Foley, Steven. 2013. The syntax of Georgian relative clauses. Senior honors thesis, New York University.

Conference proceedings

Foley, Steven, Vera Lee-Schoenfeld, and Jill McLendon. 2026. Sorting things right out: An analysis of English particle verbs without object movement. In *Proceedings of the Linguistic Society of America*, 11(1).

Foley, Steven. 2025. Processing Philippine and Reverse Philippine case alignment. In Alessa Farinella and Jed Pizarro-Guevara (eds.), *Proceedings of the Thirty-First Meeting of the Austronesian Formal Linguistics Association* (*AFLA*). 83–95.

Foley, Steven, and Maziar Toosarvandani. 2019. Pronoun cliticization, *wh*-movement, and the Principle of Minimal Compliance. In Maggie Baird and Jonathan Pesetsky (eds.), *Proceedings of the 49th North East Linguistics Society* (*NELS 49*). 251–264.

Foley, Steven, Nick Kalivoda, and Maziar Toosarvandani. 2019. Gender–Case constraints in Zapotec. To appear in Anne Bertrand and Heather Burge (eds.), *Proceedings of the 22nd Workshop on Structure and Constituency in Languages of the Americas* (*WSCLA 22*). University of British Columbia Working Papers in Linguistics.

Foley, Steven, Nick Kalivoda, and Maziar Toosarvandani. 2019. Forbidden clitic clusters in Zapotec. In Daniel Edmiston, Marina Ermolaeva, Emre Hakgüder, Jackie Lai, Kathryn Montemurro, Brandon Rhodes, Amara Sankhagowit, and Michael Tabatowski (eds.), *Proceedings of the 53rd Chicago Linguistics Society* (*CLS 53*). 87–102.

Foley, Steven. 2017. Morphological conspiracies in Georgian and Optimal Vocabulary Insertion. In Jessica Kantarovich, Tran Truong, and Orest Xherija (eds.), *Proceedings of the 52nd Chicago Linguistics Society* (*CLS 52*). 217–232.

Invited presentations

Foley, Steven. 2026. Grammar or processor? The case of Exceptional Object Agreement in Georgian. Concours de chargé de recherche, Centre National de la Recherche Scientifique (CNRS). Paris, France. March 10.

Foley, Steven. 2025. Singular *they* and variation in sentence processing behavior. Linguistics department colloquium, University of Georgia. Athens, GA. January 31.

Foley, Steven. 2024. Morphological variation and reanalysis in Georgian placeholder verbs. Invited talk, *CauLaGe* (*Caucasian Languages in Georgia*) *Talk Series*. Structures Formelles du Langage, University Paris 8 and Laboratoire de Linguistique, Nantes University. December 6.

Foley, Steven. 2024. Comprehending ambiguous cues to thematic role in Georgian. Linguistics department colloquium, Johns Hopkins University. Baltimore, MD. April 2.

Foley, Steven. 2024. Case, word order, and the comprehension of grammatical complexity in Georgian. Linguistics department colloquium, Simon Fraser University. Burnaby, BC. February 29.

Foley, Steven and Léa Nash. 2023. Experimental Syntax. Tutorial at the third South Caucasian Chalk Circle (SCCC-3), Ilia State University. Tbilisi, Georgia. October 2–4.

Foley, Steven. 2019. Why are ergatives hard to process? Reading-time evidence from Georgian. Linguistics department colloquium, University of Massachusetts Amherst. Amherst, MA. March 1.

Refereed conference presentations

Foley, Steven, Jérémy Pasquereau, and Léa Nash. 2026. Prominence, intervention, and attraction in Georgian agreement. Poster presented at the 44th West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics (WCCFL 44). Universidad Nacional Autónoma de México, Mexico City, Mexico. May 6–7.

Foley, Steven, Vera Lee-Schoenfeld, and Jill McLendon. 2026. Sorting things right out: An analysis of English particle verbs without object movement. Paper presented at the 2026 Linguistic Society of America Annual Meeting. New Orleans, Louisiana. January 8–11.

Foley, Steven, and Nino Amiridze. 2025. Multiple grammars of Georgian placeholder verbs coexist across speakers. Paper presented at the 4th South Caucasian Chalk Circle (SCCC-4). University of Paris 8, Paris, France. October 7–10.

Processing Philippine and Reverse Philippine alignment. Paper presented at the 31st Annual Meeting of the Austronesian Formal Linguistics Association (AFLA). University of Massachusetts, Amherst, MA. June 12–14.

Foley, Steven. 2024. Processing Philippine and Reverse Philippine alignment. Paper presented at the 31st Annual Meeting of the Austronesian Formal Linguistics Association (AFLA). University of Massachusetts, Amherst, MA. June 12–14.

Foley, Steven, Byron Ahn, and Lauren Ackerman. 2024. Number, animacy, and individual variation in the processing of cataphora. Poster presented at the 37th Annual Society for Human Sentence Processing (HSP). University of Michigan, Ann Arbor, MI. May 16–18.

Foley, Steven and Nino Amiridze. 2023. How verbs are placeheld/placeholded in Georgian. Poster presented at the South Caucasian Chalk Circle (SCCC-3). Ilia State University, Tbilisi, Georgia. October 2–4.

Foley, Steven, Lizi Baramidze, Tamar Kalkhitashvili, Natia Poniava, and Irakli Salia. 2023. Comprehending verb finality and case ambiguity in real time. Talk at the South Caucasian Chalk Circle (SCCC-3). Ilia State University, Tbilisi, Georgia. October 2–4.

Amiridze, Nino and Steven Foley. 2023. Whether verbs are placeheld or placeholded in Georgian: An acceptability study. Poster presented at the workshop on Locality in Theory, Processing, and Acquisition (LTPA). University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia, PA. March 31 – April 1.

Foley, Steven, Kirby Conrod, Byron Ahn, Ameena Faruki, Xander Guidry, and Ruth Schultz. 2023. Depending on their social group, does the comprehender process cataphora differently? Virtual poster presented at the 36th Annual Society for Human Sentence Processing (HSP). University of Pittsburgh, Pittsburgh, PA. March 9–11.

Ahn, Byron, Kirby Conrod, Ameena Faruki, Steven Foley, Xander Guidry, and Ruth Schultz. 2022. Acceptability, production, and comprehension of definite singular *they*. Project-launch paper presented at New Ways of Analyzing Variation (NWAV 50). Stanford University, Palo Alto, CA. October 13–15.

Foley, Steven. 2022. Quantifying performance constraints on case-alignment typology with information theory. Poster presented at the 35th Annual Conference on Human Sentence Processing (HSP 2022). University of California Santa Cruz, Santa Cruz, CA. March 24–26. Video presentation: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TYdWJt44NfE>

Foley, Steven and Matt Wagers. 2021. Predicting syntactic role in a split-ergative language: Reading-time and corpus evidence from Georgian. Paper presented at Crosslinguistic Perspectives on Processing and Learning (X-PPL). University of Zurich, Zurich, Switzerland. September 16–17.

Foley, Steven and Matt Wagers. 2020. Prominence scales guide incremental sentence comprehension in Georgian. Poster presented at the 33rd Annual CUNY Conference on Human Sentence Processing (CUNY 33). University of Massachusetts Amherst, Amherst, MA. March 19–21.

Foley, Steven. 2019. The Principle Minimal Compliance and derivational competition in South Caucasian agreement. Poster presented at the 50th Annual Meeting of the North East Linguistics Society (NELS 50). Massachusetts Institute of Technology, Cambridge, MA. October 25–27.

Foley, Steven. 2019. Object agreement in South Caucasian via the Principle of Minimal Compliance. Paper presented at Object Agreement Across Barriers. University of Zagreb, Zagreb, Croatia. September 16–17.

Foley, Steven and Matt Wagers. 2019. Computing object agreement is easier than computing subject agreement in Georgian. Poster presented at the 32nd Annual CUNY Conference on Human Sentence Processing (CUNY 32). University of Colorado, Boulder, CO. March 29–31.

Foley, Steven, Jed Pizarro-Guevarra, Kelsey Sasaki, Maziar Toosarvandani, and Matt Wagers. 2019. Pronouns over gaps in parsing? The Subject Relative Clause Advantage in Santiago Laxopa Zapotec. Paper presented at the 93rd Annual Meeting of the Linguistic Society of America (LSA 93), New York City, NY. January 3–6.

Foley, Steven and Matt Wagers. 2018. Detecting agreement errors in Georgian: Implications for predictive parsing. Paper presented at the 2nd Annual California Meeting on Psycholinguistics (CAMP 2). University of Southern California, Los Angeles, CA. December 1–2.

Foley, Steven and Maziar Toosarvandani. 2018. Pronominal cliticization, multiple *wh*-movement, and Probe Generosity. Paper presented at the 49th Annual Meeting of the North East Linguistics Society (NELS 49). Cornell University, Ithaca, NY. October 5–7.

Foley, Steven and Matt Wagers. 2017. The Subject Gap Preference in a split-ergative language: Reading time evidence from Georgian. Paper presented at the 48th Annual Meeting of the North East Linguistics Society (NELS 48). University of Iceland, Reykjavík, Iceland. October 27–29.

Foley, Steven, Nick Kalivoda, and Maziar Toosarvandani. 2017. Forbidden clitic clusters in Zapotec. Paper presented at the 53rd Annual Meeting of the Chicago Linguistics Society (CLS 53). University of Chicago, Chicago, IL. May 25–27.

Foley, Steven, Nick Kalivoda, and Maziar Toosarvandani. 2017. Forbidden clitic clusters in Zapotec. Paper presented at the 22rd Workshop on Structure and Constituency in Languages of the Americas (WSCLA 22). University of British Columbia, Vancouver, Canada. May 25–27.

Foley, Steven and Matt Wagers. 2017. Subject gaps are still easiest: Relative clause processing and Georgian split ergativity. Poster presented at the 30th Annual CUNY Conference on Human Sentence Processing (CUNY 30). Massachusetts Institute of Technology, Cambridge, MA. March 30 – April 1.

Adler, Jeff, Steven Foley, Jed Pizarro-Guevara, Kelsey Sasaki, and Maziar Toosarvandani. 2017. The derivation of verb- initiality of Santiago Laxopa Zapotec. Paper presented at Society for the Study of Indigenous Languages of the Americas Annual Meeting (SSILA). University of Texas, Austin, TX. January 5–8.

Foley, Steven. 2016. Case–agreement mismatches in Georgian. Poster presented at the South Caucasian Chalk Circle (SCCC-1), Paris, France. September 22–24.

Foley, Steven. 2016. Morphological conspiracies and the nature of Vocabulary Insertion. Paper presented at the 52nd Annual Meeting of the Chicago Linguistics Society (CLS 52). University of Chicago, Chicago, IL. April 21–23.

Foley, Steven. 2015. Is the Subset Principle Violable? The view from Georgian agreement. Paper presented at the 11th International Tbilisi Symposium on Language, Logic, and Cognition (TbiLLC XI). Tbilisi State University, Tbilisi, Georgia. September 21–26.

Foley, Steven. 2013. Songhay relative clauses. Paper presented at SUNY–Yale–NYU–CUNY Linguistics Graduate Conference (SYNC 15). Yale University, New Haven, CT. December 7.

Foley, Steven. 2013. A unified derivation of relative clauses in Georgian. Paper presented at the Cornell Undergraduate Linguistics Colloquium (CULC 7). Cornell University, Ithaca, NY. April 20–21.

Teaching experience

As visiting assistant professor at the University of Georgia

Spring semester 2026	*Psycholinguistics*
	Less-Taught Languages: Grammatical Structure of Georgian
Fall semester 2025	*Experimental Methods in Linguistics*
	The Study of Language (introduction to linguistics)
Spring semester 2025	*Psycholinguistics*
	The Study of Language (introduction to linguistics)
Fall semester 2024	*Language, Mind, and Brain*
	Special Topics in Linguistics: Constructed Languages

As postdoctoral teaching fellow at the University of Southern California

Spring semester 2024	*Syntax & Grammatical Theory* (graduate-level)
Fall semester 2023	*Seminar in Syntax* (topic: argument structure)
Spring semester 2023	*Advanced Syntax* (undergraduate-level)
	Syntax & Grammatical Theory (graduate-level)

As postdoctoral lecturer at Princeton University

Spring semester 2021	*Constructed Languages: From Elvish to Esperanto*
Fall semester 2020	*Mythbusting Language*

As graduate student instructor at UC Santa Cruz

Fall quarter 2019	*Poetry & Language*
Spring quarter 2019	*Native Languages of North America*

As graduate student teaching assistant at UC Santa Cruz

Spring quarter 2020	*Introduction to Linguistics*

Winter quarter 2020	*Typology*
Winter quarter 2019	*Semantics I*
Fall quarter 2018	*Introduction to Linguistics*
Summer quarter 2018	*Invented Languages: From Elvish to Esperanto*
Spring quarter 2017	*Pragmatics*
Winter quarter 2017	*Syntax I*
Fall quarter 2016	*Psycholinguistics & Linguistic Theory*
Spring quarter 2016	*Poetry & Language*
Winter quarter 2016	*Phonology I*
Fall quarter 2015	*Phonology II*

Advising experience

As primary advisor

Lawrence, Susanna. 2025. Comparing behavioral and neurophysiological responses to interrogation techniques. Center for Undergraduate Research Opportunity (CURO) research award project, University of Georgia.

Yeung, Michael. 2021. Iconicity in language comprehension: A plausibility study on sound symbolism from Cantonese ideophones. BA thesis, Princeton University.

Service

Editorial service

7/2026 – present	Editorial board member, *Caucasus Survey*
7/2026 – present	Editorial board member, *Syntax: A Journal of Theoretical, Experimental and Interdisciplinary Research*

Organization

4/2016 – 6/2017	$\overline{\text{S}}$-Circle, UCSC's syntax reading group
9/2015 – 6/2017	S-Circle, UCSC's syntax–semantics speaker series

Ad hoc reviewing of journal articles

Frontiers in Psychology

Glossa

Glossa Psycholinguistics

Journal of Linguistics

Journal of Memory and Language

Journal of Psycholinguistic Research

Language

Linguistic Inquiry

Linguistic Typology

Natural Language and Linguistic Theory

Poznań Studies in Contemporary Linguistics

Ad hoc reviewing of conference abstracts

Architectures and Mechanisms for Language Processing (AMLaP)

California Meeting on Psycholinguistics (CAMP)

Linguistic Society of America Annual Meeting (LSA)

Society for Human Sentence Processing (HSP)

West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics (WCCFL)

Miscellaneous

Other education

July 2016	Eastern Generative Grammar (EGG), Summer school in linguistics, Lagodekhi, Georgia
July 2013	New York / St. Petersburg Institute of Linguistics, Cognition & Culture (NYI), Summer school in linguistics, St. Petersburg, Russia
6/2011 – 8/2011	Middlebury School of Russian, Middlebury VT

Language abilities

North American English (native)

Georgian (intermediate)

Spanish (intermediate)

Grants and awards

2019 Mary Turner Gilliland and Clinton Gilliland Award, Phi Beta Kappa Northern California Association

2014 Recommended candidate, Fulbright Research Grant to Georgia

2013 Alumni Association Award, NYU

2013 Elected to Phi Beta Kappa

2013 Robert A. Fowkes Award, NYU Department of Linguistics

Visual arts exhibitions

2025 *Spilled Fruit*, Group show curated by Chance Weick at The Future Front House, Austin, TX

Last Updated: September 29, 2026